

Chapter 27_1 - Competition

Bai Lin¹ hung his head dejectedly and followed her for a few steps, then paused and looked back disappointedly toward the grass.

Chu Qingqiu ahead had already disappeared. Bai Lin suddenly dropped his tail and ran back, struggling to pick up the grass-stained clothes in his mouth, carefully placing them by the door. He even used his paws to brush away the grass leaves from the fabric.

Only then did he hang his head, which was twice the size of his body, and walk back to Jingshan Palace² with drooping brows and downcast eyes.

Chu Qingqiu came quietly and left quietly. No one in the house noticed that someone had lingered outside the door, especially since Ning Fuyi's attention was entirely focused on how to avoid Du Baishuang.

"Thank you for the trouble of sewing this, but I don't lack for clothes. You should keep it and wear it yourself." Ning Fuyi glanced at the embroidery on it, then calmly pushed the garment back into Du Baishuang's hands.

"But if Elder Sister won't accept it, I can never repay this debt, and my heart will always feel indebted. What shall I do if this weighs on my mind day and night?" Seeing Ning Fuyi wouldn't accept it, Du Baishuang became anxious, her peach blossom eyes filling with tears.

"Besides, Elder Sister's clothes..." Du Baishuang said, lowering her gaze. Ning Fuyi followed her line of sight and saw the corner of her own skirt that had been burned by fire during the day.

"You needn't worry. This is just casual wear - if it's damaged, I'll simply replace it. Besides, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate disciples all have sect robes³. I won't need these in daily life." Ning Fuyi spoke firmly, pushing Du Baishuang's outstretched hands back to her chest.

"I said no, so there's no need to offer again." She added.

Her words were cold, combined with her lowered phoenix eyes, making Du Baishuang immediately afraid to speak further. She only stood there with tears in her eyes.

This appearance would have earned anyone else's pity, but Ning Fuyi had never had the awareness to cherish delicate beauties. She glanced outside and put on a kind expression: "It's getting late. Even Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate isn't completely safe. You should return to your room quickly."

With that, she opened the door and half-pulled, half-pushed the young girl outside. After the girl left with frequent backward glances, Ning Fuyi finally closed the door heavily and sighed.

This Du Baishuang - though still young, her temperament was exactly the same as in her previous life.

However, she had told a lie just now to refuse her. She clearly had no sect robes but claimed she did. Ning Fuyi turned and walked back to the study, muttering to herself that she'd have to find Elder Jingshan⁴ tomorrow to remind him.

After fiddling around at the desk for a while longer, she finally stretched and blew out the candle, preparing to return to Pearl Light Pavilion⁵. But just as she stepped over the threshold, she stepped on something and quickly lifted her foot.

By the bright moonlight, she could see what looked like folded clothes on the ground. She reached down to pick them up, and the silky smooth fabric fell like a waterfall as it unfolded.

Holding it felt light as air, like wind that couldn't be grasped. The color was like the tenderest grass leaves - green interwoven with clean white, looking spirited and full of vigor.

Ning Fuyi raised her eyebrows slightly and looked into the distance, but around her were only the dappled shadows of bamboo leaves in the moonlight and the moon like a silver disk. There was no trace of anyone's presence.

She could feel this garment's fabric was different - it definitely wasn't an ordinary sect robe, but the style was the same as other disciples'. It certainly wasn't the one Du Baishuang had made either.

Looking closely, she could see the stitching was fine and delicate. Though it had no embroidery, she could feel immortal power flowing gently through it.

"This stitching looks exactly like Senior Brother Rong Jin's work." Ning Fuyi murmured to herself, then smiled brightly. "No wonder I didn't see Senior Brother today - he was off making clothes."

Since she had grown up, it had been several years since she'd worn clothes made by Rong Jin. Having found the whereabouts of the Emei spike⁶ and now receiving sect robes, Ning Fuyi was in an excellent mood. She hummed a tune all the way back to Pearl Light Pavilion.

Because of tomorrow's selection, there weren't many people resting in Pearl Light Pavilion. Most disciples had gone to the back mountain for intensive cultivation, hoping to earn a chance to attend the Zhaoyao Conference⁷. Only Ning Fuyi went to bed early, closing her eyes to sleep.

With just immortal power alone, she definitely couldn't be selected, so she had to conserve her energy for tomorrow.

To gain power as soon as possible, to avoid repeating past mistakes, she had to use any means necessary.

The next day at cockcrow, Ning Fuyi opened her eyes. The sky was still dark. She reached for yesterday's sect robe and dressed. This garment was indeed different - when she first put it on, it felt like wearing nothing, but after a while, it seemed to merge with her skin, warming her entire body.

What made her even more delighted was that the wide sleeves actually had a small brocade pouch sewn inside. Though it couldn't store things like a Memory Bead⁸, it still had considerable space. Ning Fuyi patted it with satisfaction and threw the items she had worked on yesterday inside.

She must find an opportunity today to properly thank Rong Jin, she thought.

After dining alone in the hall, Ning Fuyi finally saw Liu Wenzhu returning from the back mountain, covered in dust with several torn grass blades hanging from her shoulders. Clearly, she hadn't slept all night.

"Yiyi." Seeing Ning Fuyi, she approached with a bitter expression. "I'm so nervous my hands are shaking. What should I do?"

"What's there to fear?" Ning Fuyi reached out to remove the grass from her shoulder. "You're the great Miss Liu - how could you lose to them?"

"But I haven't learned the sword techniques the elders taught yet." Liu Wenzhu exhaled and gripped the sword in her hand tightly. "I don't know if I'll face Li Zhao'an⁹. Though she's hateful, she's still considered a genius among our generation of disciples. She broke through to Clear Realm¹⁰ long ago. If I face her, I'll definitely be eliminated."

Li Zhao'an. She was indeed an opponent, Ning Fuyi thought secretly.

"Alright, alright, trust me - you'll definitely make it to the Zhaoyao Conference." Ning Fuyi consoled her with a beaming smile, then took her wrist and headed toward Cloud Deep Hall¹¹.

The dawn had already broken. The distant dark mountains gradually became clear under the morning sun's illumination. The mountain mist dispersed, and the trees deepened their emerald color.

Today was cloudless. The wide white jade platform in front of Cloud Deep Hall was completely visible. Three or four disciples had already arrived and were practicing with their magical implements, striking brilliant lights in mid-air. In the distance, tables and chairs had been arranged on the steps at the entrance of Cloud Deep Hall for the elders' use.

Suddenly a whistle sounded. All disciples immediately stopped their movements and walked toward Elder Pingyao¹², who had appeared at the center of the white jade platform at some unknown time, forming several rows.

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu stood at the back of the formation, listening to Elder Pingyao speak.

"All of you are here to participate in the selection. Naturally, you know this is different from ordinary sparring. Everyone must give their all, but you must not harm fellow disciples' lives. Anyone who violates this order will be immediately expelled from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate." Elder Pingyao's loud voice amplified several times, echoing in mid-air.

"This selection has three rounds. First is a test of wisdom, second is immortal power, and third is actual combat. Finally, the sect leader and elders will jointly select candidates based on everyone's performance. Have you all heard clearly?"

Everyone responded in unison, then lowered their heads to whisper among themselves.

"There's actually a wisdom test too! I thought it would just be fighting. I might be able to win in martial prowess, but when it comes to using my brain, I'm at wit's end!" The disciple in front of Ning Fuyi said indignantly.

"Yes, I practiced sword techniques all night yesterday. My head still hurts - how can I think clearly now?" Groans arose from the crowd.

"Silence!" Elder Pingyao said sternly. Everyone immediately fell quiet. She swept her long sleeve, and dozens of stone tables appeared in front of the hall, each separated by an arm's width, arranged in neat squares.

"Stand behind your assigned table according to the names I call." Elder Pingyao picked up the roster in her hand and began calling names one by one.

"Shi Shuishui¹³, Qiu Yong, Fan Zimo, Shao Bing, Mian Tiao... Liu Wenzhu, Ning Fuyi, Li Zhao'an."

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu's names were called last. Following the others' example, they stood behind their stone tables. The morning sun was already somewhat dazzling. Ning Fuyi squinted toward the front - the formation of dozens of people arranged in squares had quite an imposing air. The shaded area in front of the hall was now filled with many people. Besides the familiar elders and managing disciples from various courtyards, there was also Mei Chengsi¹⁴, whom she hadn't seen in a long time. He had a serious expression, his brocade robe embroidered with golden threads glittering brilliantly in the sun.

Ning Fuyi looked to the other side, and Chu Qingqiu's graceful figure entered her view. Today she unusually wasn't wearing all white, but had changed to a deep blue dress. That color was like the deep seabed, making her overall temperament appear majestic and calm, while her exposed skin appeared even more snow-white.

Ning Fuyi only glanced once before looking away, lowering her gaze to stare at the stone table.

Suddenly there was a "pop" sound, and an ordinary-looking wooden box appeared on each stone table. The box's surface had crisscrossing patterns, resembling an extremely complex mortise and tenon structure¹⁵, yet completely different.

"Mechanism arts¹⁶ - profound and exquisite, essential techniques that our sect's disciples must study. Now you have one incense stick's time. Any disciple who fails to solve this mechanism and retrieve the object inside will be eliminated!" After Elder Pingyao finished speaking, she gestured toward the front of the hall. A managing disciple ran before everyone and lit an incense stick.

Upon hearing this, everyone hurriedly bent down to fiddle with the mechanisms. Soon there were banging sounds everywhere, mixed with continuous sighs. Everyone in sight was scratching their heads.

But Ning Fuyi felt a surge of joy. In her previous life, her talent was poor. Seeing she couldn't learn immortal arts, Ning Changfeng simply taught her mechanism arts privately, intending that even after his death, she could make a living with mechanism skills. Therefore, she was quite accomplished in solving various mechanisms.

A clang came from beside her. Ning Fuyi looked sideways and met Li Zhao'an's smug gaze and her deliberately exaggerated mouth movements: "You actually dare participate in the selection - you really aren't afraid of embarrassment!"

Ning Fuyi didn't speak but picked up the box on the table. After her fingertips explored it once, she heard a click as the first lock opened.

Li Zhao'an's expression immediately changed. Too late to provoke further, she hurriedly bent down to fiddle with her own mechanism box.

Ning Fuyi's lips curved in an imperceptible smile. She didn't look away but kept staring at Li Zhao'an. When she finally unlocked her first lock, Ning Fuyi flicked her finger and opened the second lock with a click.

Watching Li Zhao'an's expression like she'd eaten something disgusting, if it weren't for the ongoing competition, Ning Fuyi would have thrown her head back and laughed aloud.

So she followed Li Zhao'an's pace, unlocking mechanisms all the way. When Li Zhao'an was sweating profusely as she solved the second-to-last lock, Ning Fuyi held up her box high, indicating her completion while clicking open the final lock.

All eyes on the field immediately focused on her raised hand. The box was already open, revealing a pitch-black stone inside. Upon contact with air, the stone rapidly expanded to half the size of a wall, landing steadily on the stone table.

There was an uproar around her. Some people hurriedly turned back to solve their own boxes, while others exclaimed in surprise.

"How did she solve it!"

"She never pays attention during lessons normally - how is she first now?"

"Quick, quick, quick! Don't waste time - half the incense has burned!" Someone cursed in frustration until Elder Pingyao spoke, restoring quiet.

"Enough!" Elder Pingyao said loudly. She quickly walked to Ning Fuyi's side and examined the mechanism box. After confirming it was indeed solved through the mechanism, she looked at Ning Fuyi's face in surprise.

She raised her hand: "Ning Fuyi, passed."

At these words, even the elders in front of the hall were shocked and looked at each other in amazement. Finally, Elder Jingshan frowned and spoke: "Sect Leader, this Ning Fuyi has always been unruly and her cultivation is extraordinarily poor. The mechanism box was designed by me personally - it's absolutely beyond her intelligence to solve. I should go check again to see if she used some trick."

Just as he was about to stand, he was stopped by Elder Yuanming¹⁷ beside him. That thick-browed, kind-faced man had a benevolent smile, but his words weren't so gentle: "Elder Jingshan speaks wrongly. Elder Pingyao's mechanism skills are no less than yours. Since even Elder Pingyao said nothing, what do you have to doubt?"

"You!" Elder Jingshan was about to retort when he was interrupted by Mei Chengsi, who stroked his beard and smiled: "Elder Yuanming speaks reasonably. Since Elder Pingyao has confirmed it, this venerable trusts Elder Pingyao."

He said this halfway, then turned to Chu Qingqiu, his eyes smiling into slits: "What does the Divine Venerable think?"

Chu Qingqiu's gaze had been fixed on the distant Ning Fuyi. Hearing this, a fierce look flashed in her eyes, then she only said flatly, "Likewise."

The disciples didn't know about the undercurrents in front of the hall and were still working hard to solve the puzzles. At this time, led by Li Zhao'an, others gradually solved their mechanisms, with similar black giant stones appearing on their tables.

Ning Fuyi noticed Li Zhao'an's angry gaze but no longer looked at her. Instead, she high-fived Liu Wenzhu, who had just completed the mechanism with a flushed red face from anxiety.

"Excellent." Liu Wenzhu secretly gave her a thumbs up.

When the incense burned out, disciples who hadn't completed the task left dejectedly. The formation that had been dozens strong was suddenly reduced by half, making the remaining participants even more nervous and silent.

"Next round - see the stones you opened earlier? These are Diamond Dark Stones¹⁸, which cannot be broken by human strength alone and require immortal power infusion to shatter them. Same time - one incense stick. Those who fail to make them crack will be eliminated!" Elder Pingyao's voice rang out again. The managing disciple lit another incense stick, sending wisps of green smoke into the sky.

People had no time for chatter and bent their heads, releasing various colored lights from their palms to infuse into the stones before them. For a moment, the entire white jade platform was filled with multicolored brilliance - viewed from above, it would look like a magnificent galaxy, quite spectacular.

This time Ning Fuyi wasn't so relaxed. Her cultivation was limited - how could her immortal power compare to others? She could only grit her teeth and persevere.

Stones around her cracked one by one, with successive cheers arising. Only Ning Fuyi and a few other Mortal Realm disciples continued. Ning Fuyi had no time to listen to others' mockery but suddenly switched to using both hands, redirecting what little power she had within her body, giving it her all.

In the end, only she remained. Many people were sweating for her. Finally, in the instant before the incense burned out, the stone before her cracked open with a crack. Ning Fuyi stepped back two steps, breathing heavily, only then realizing sweat had already soaked her clothes.

"Yiyi, you did it!" Liu Wenzhu called out loudly, hugging her shoulders and taking out a handkerchief from her bosom to wipe away her sweat. At the same time, Elder Pingyao blew her whistle, announcing the end of the second round.

Perhaps this round was simpler - no one else was eliminated. The stone tables on the field were removed one by one, replaced by three square arenas made of jade. The space above the arenas was surrounded by translucent membranes, forming huge covers to protect outsiders from injury.

"I feel like the real competition is just beginning." Behind Ning Fuyi, the bald male disciple's legs were shaking. "I've never properly sparred with anyone before. Now if I don't break a leg, I probably won't be able to get off the stage."

"Stop talking so defeatedly." The girl with the sky-high braids scolded him.

While the disciples here were anxious, Elder Pingyao had already begun calling names. Those called were paired two by two and entered one of the arenas, with three groups competing simultaneously.

The first wave of three groups didn't include anyone Ning Fuyi recognized, but most used fire and thunder techniques. Soon the transparent covers were filled with blue lightning and yellow-red flames, crackling like a tribulation¹⁹, shaking the entire Cloud Deep Hall and frightening the disciples who hadn't yet competed until their faces turned pale.

When one round ended and the people inside emerged supporting each other with blackened faces, this terrifying emotion spread even more thoroughly.

At this moment, Ning Fuyi had no demonic power, and everything before her was unknown. She slightly closed her eyes and silently recited the incantations she had remembered last night.

Soon her name was called. After Ning Fuyi opened her eyes, her heart immediately sank. She saw Li Zhao'an standing before her, smiling as she waved the thousand-year-rare precious sword that was crackling in her hands.

"Young Sect Leader, that's Li Zhao'an. Why don't you just admit defeat?" The bald male disciple said carefully behind her. "Her cultivation level can dominate the North Courtyard - you can't beat her."

"If the Young Sect Leader feels embarrassed, just take a couple of moves then beg for mercy. That's better than missing arms and legs." The girl with sky-high braids kindly advised.

Liu Wenzhu, who was also called, frowned and blocked in front of her, saying softly: "This is too unfair. I'll ask Elder Pingyao to let us switch opponents."

"No need." Ning Fuyi spoke. She gently pulled Liu Wenzhu aside, reached for the weapon rack nearby, casually drew a sword, held it firmly in her palm, her voice ominous.

She had long been unable to tolerate this Li Zhao'an.

Cold light flashed in her eyes: "Why should I be the one missing arms and legs?"

At Elder Pingyao's command, the second group of disciples entered the covers. Exclamations came from in front of Cloud Deep Hall as a managing disciple said: "Isn't that Ning Fuyi? If I'm not mistaken, her opponent is Li Zhao'an?"

"Li Zhao'an is one of the few geniuses among the young disciples of this generation. With Ning Fuyi facing her, won't she lose her life?"

"What nonsense!" Rong Jin²⁰ said. "I'll ask Elder Pingyao to change opponents."

"Stop!" Elder Jingshan scolded. "Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate has always been fair. She could have chosen to withdraw before the match. Since she didn't choose to, if her skills are inferior, she should be eliminated. What's this about changing opponents!"

All disciples were ready. With Elder Pingyao's command, thunderous roars suddenly erupted from the central arena. Dark clouds completely blocked the cover, and dozens of lightning bolts simultaneously struck the thin green figure. That person was immediately knocked to the ground, like earth-shattering thunder, making even the distant mountains seem to shake.

Chu Qingqiu suddenly stood up but was grabbed by the wrist by Mei Chengsi beside her, who stroked his beard and smiled: "This is just disciples sparring - there are bound to be winners and losers. Why is the Divine Venerable so agitated?"

The central arena had fallen silent. The dark clouds slowly dispersed, revealing the collapsed body on the ground was indeed Ning Fuyi. The onlookers all gasped in horror, approaching slowly in terror. Some screamed loudly, demanding the match be stopped.

No one could see Chu Qingqiu's movements clearly. The scalding copper teapot beside her suddenly opened its lid by itself, and a pot of tea splashed entirely onto Mei Chengsi's face. While scalding his skin red, it also made him fall backward, having to let go of Chu Qingqiu's hand and falling awkwardly on his back.

At the same time, just as Chu Qingqiu was about to flash forward, Rong Jin suddenly pointed at the arena and shouted loudly: "Divine Venerable, look quickly! Fuyi - Fuyi is standing up!"

Footnotes:

1. **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Chu Qingqiu's spirit beast companion, a white tiger that can transform
 2. **Jingshan Palace (静山宫)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence
 3. **Sect robes (门服)** - Special ceremonial clothing for sect members with magical properties
 4. **Elder Jingshan (景山长老)** - One of the four great elders, manages disciples' daily needs
 5. **Pearl Light Pavilion (珠光阁)** - Ning Fuyi's dormitory
 6. **Emei spike (峨眉刺)** - Ning Fuyi's magical weapon from her previous life
 7. **Zhaoyao Conference (招摇大会)** - A major cultivation conference and competition
 8. **Memory Bead (一念珠)** - A storage device that can hold items in a dimensional space
 9. **Li Zhao'an (李朝安)** - A talented disciple who harbors jealousy toward Ning Fuyi
 10. **Clear Realm (明境)** - One of the cultivation realms in the story's power system
 11. **Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿)** - A major hall used for important sect events
 12. **Elder Pingyao (平遥长老)** - One of the strict teaching elders overseeing the selection
 13. **Character names** - Various disciple names called for the selection
 14. **Mei Chengsi (梅承嗣)** - Current sect leader of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
 15. **Mortise and tenon (榫卯)** - Traditional Chinese woodworking joints without nails
 16. **Mechanism arts (机关术)** - The study of mechanical devices and contraptions
 17. **Elder Yuanming (元明长老)** - One of the four great elders, generally supportive of Ning Fuyi
 18. **Diamond Dark Stones (金刚玄石)** - Mystical stones that require immortal power to break
 19. **Tribulation (渡劫)** - A trial by heavenly lightning that cultivators must face
 20. **Rong Jin (容锦)** - Ning Fuyi's senior brother and friend
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Author's Notes: This chapter sets up the crucial selection trials that will determine who attends the Zhaoyao Conference. Ning Fuyi's unexpected success in the mechanism test surprises everyone, while the brewing confrontation with Li Zhao'an promises intense drama. The subplot with the mysterious sect robes from Chu Qingqiu adds romantic tension to the competitive atmosphere.